



A BLOODHOLLOW RESEARCH FOLIO

BLOOD & BANNERS

Chronicles of the old Korean MMORPG wars —
politics, sieges & betrayal, 1997-2016

LINEAGE - HELBREATH - DARK EDEN - SOMA - BARTZ - EVERQUEST EAST - MIR - DARKFALL

compiled 2026-09-15

HOW TO READ THIS FOLIO

This is a history of governments that never existed. Between 1997 and 2016, a handful of Korean (and Korea-adjacent) online worlds — Lineage, Helbreath, Dark Eden, Myth of Soma, Lineage II, the Asian experiments of EverQuest, the Chinese mirror of Legend of Mir, and the Greek heir Darkfall — let players tax each other, monopolize land, declare war, spy, defect, and revolt. The chapters that follow retell those wars as political history, because that is what they were.

Every factual claim is footnoted to the source registry printed in the back. Where sources disagree — Helbreath's exact commercial date, Dark Eden's birth year — the disagreement is flagged as **contested** instead of being silently arbitrated. Two kinds of pictures appear:

ILLUSTRATION (AI) plates are evocative paintings in the period style and are not game assets; **ARCHIVAL FRAME** plates are real captured frames archived in this repository's research dossiers (docs/research-notes/).

The folio was compiled for the BloodHollow team as ancestral research: our own design pillar four — politics as endgame — is a direct inheritance from these wars. Read it as a chronicle, mine it as a design document.

CONVENTIONS

GAME TITLES set italic on first use per chapter; Korean titles given where they matter.

DATES KST-era dates as published; server names kept in their community spelling (Bartz, Deporoju, Unrest).

NAMES player handles preserved as recorded: Akirus, shadow□□, Red Revolution, DK, Naebok-dan.

MONEY contemporary figures quoted unadjusted; conversions as printed by the source.

Compiled 2026-09-15 on branch arena/01a0a5ea-bloodhollow. Produced by tools/build_chronicles_pdf.py from docs/prompts/ancestral-chronicles-pdf-brief.md.

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The PC-Bang Republic

Prologue — how a financial crisis built the player-state

Life was good, especially when
the internet cafe had solid bandwidth.

— after a Lineage retrospective

In November 1997 the Korean won collapsed and the Republic of Korea went to the IMF for fifty-eight billion dollars. Within three years the same country had wired itself more densely than anywhere on earth: the crisis money became cheap office space, the laid-off salarymen became PC-bang owners, and the government's broadband build-out became the plumbing for everything that follows in this book.

The PC bang was not an arcade and not a home. It was a third place with a billing address. NCsoft, founded in Seoul on 11 March 1997 by Kim Taek-jin, understood this before anyone else: instead of charging households a ~US\$20 monthly subscription, Lineage charged the cafés a licensing fee and let the players in for the price of a cola. A blood pledge could therefore assemble every night at the same physical table, shoulder to shoulder, in the same room, for the same siege. Politics that would have been impossible among strangers at home became routine among neighbours.



ILLUSTRATION (AI) A Seoul PC bang at night, 1999: the room where the pledge assemblies. The licence fee was paid by the cafe; the siege was paid by the players.

Three design accidents of the era compounded into a political technology. First, scarcity: items, castles and hunting grounds were deliberately finite, so ownership meant power over other people. Second, persistence: death, debt and taxes carried over from session to session, so grudges did too. Third, legibility: red names, karma, EK counters and pledge emblems made allegiance and reputation visible at a glance — a uniform for the player-state. Everything in the

following chapters is a variation on those three accidents.

This folio moves chronologically through the games and ends with an anatomy of the machinery they shared. The wars are real in the only sense that matters: two hundred thousand people spent four years of nights on one of them.



Lineage: The Tax State

NCsoft, 1998 — the charter of the blood pledge

Only a prince may raise a banner;
only charisma may hold it.

— charter of the blood pledge

Lineage launched in September 1998 and became, within fifteen months, a million-user polity. It was based on Shin Il-suk's manhwa of betrayed princes, and it kept the manhwa's central intuition: legitimacy is a class stat. Only the Prince/Princess class, whose defining attribute was Charisma, could found a blood pledge, declare pledge wars and castle sieges. The prince was weak alone and indispensable together — a constitutional monarchy compiled into the class table.

The siege was the franchise. Attackers broke the outer gate, fought through the courtyard to the Guardian Tower, and won only when the pledge leader touched the crown — before sunset, or the attempt dissolved. Sieges ran on a two-week cadence, and the winner became castle lord with the right to tax every player-to-NPC transaction in the territory. There was a floor of ten percent and **no ceiling**: lords squeezed fifty, sixty percent, not for profit alone but to starve rival pledges of the adena their members needed to train. Taxation was not a mechanic in Lineage; it was the mechanic.

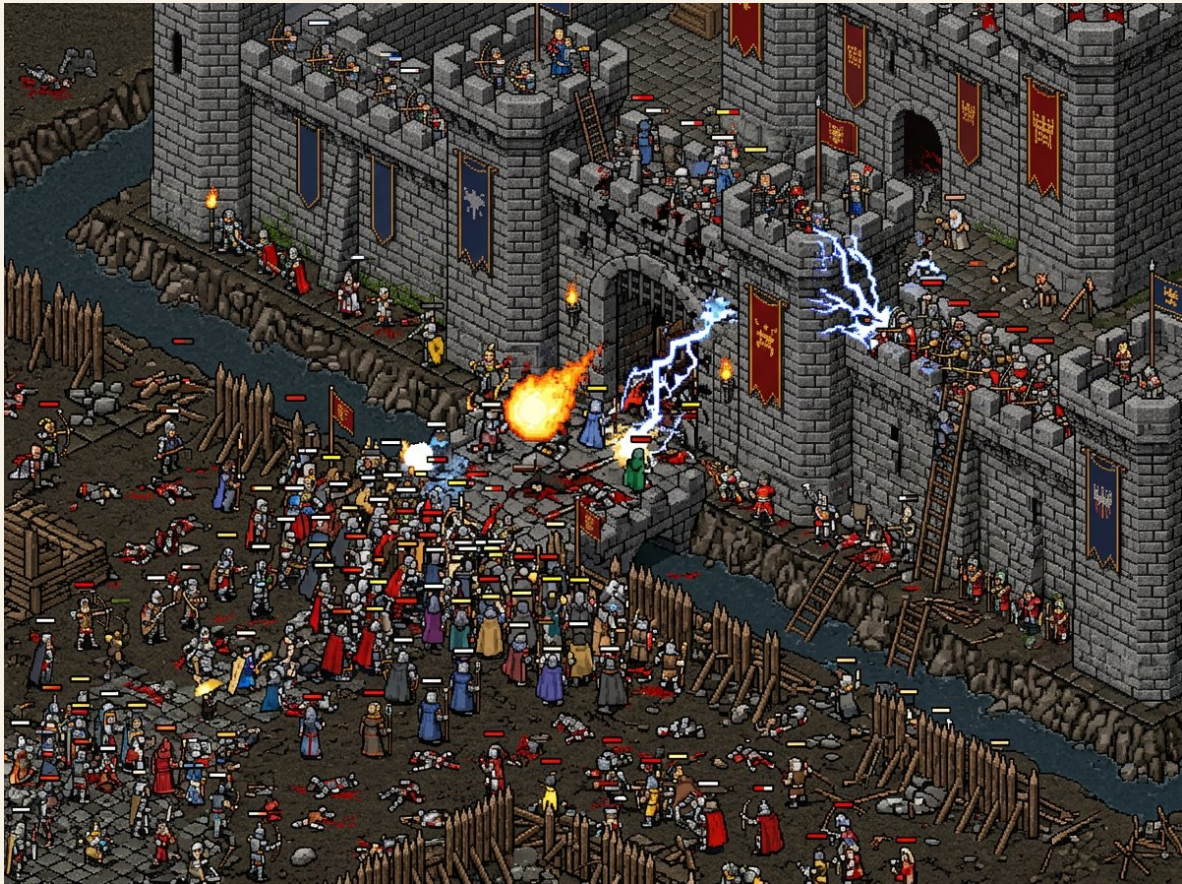


ILLUSTRATION (AI) A castle gate under assault in the period style: hundreds of sprites, one crown. Touching it before sunset was the whole of the law.

On the Deporoju server, the blood pledge DK — Dragon Knights — perfected the dark arts that every later server-politics story repeats: hunting-ground control (monopolizing the fields where experience and money spawn), boss-monster monopolies, and punitive expeditions against anyone who farmed without permission. DK held every castle on Deporoju for years and taxed accordingly. When Lineage II opened its beta in 2003, DK crossed over — and brought the template with it.



ARCHIVAL FRAME – repo dossier lineage1 Archival frames, Lineage 1: pledge bodies massed in the Tower region, name-tints marking alignment. The ground is dark, the sprites are bright; the uniform is the name.

Around the crown grew the first fully financialized player economy: open PK outside safe zones, red-name karma, and a grey market in items and whole accounts that Korean courts would spend a decade learning to price. In the West the servers went dark in June 2011 — reportedly just as the game was surging again at home. The diaspora now lives on classic-style private and remaster servers where the same pledges, grayer, still register for the same sieges.

The best thing about Lineage is that you don't have to be good at games. You have to be good at people.

after Shin Il-suk. creator of the source manhwa

DOSSIER – LINEAGE (LINEAGE 1)

DEVELOPER NCsoft, Seoul. Founded 1997-03-11 (Kim Taek-jin).

LAUNCH Korea, September 1998; based on Shin Il-suk's manhwa.

SCALE US\$1.49M revenue in 1998; >1M users in 15 months; ~4M subscriptions by 2001.

CHARTER Only Prince/Princess (Charisma) founds pledges, declares war and sieges.

TAX Castle tax floor 10%, no cap; 50-60% documented as siegecraft.

SIEGE gate -> Guardian Tower -> touch the crown before sunset; biweekly.

LEGACY DK of Deporoju invents hunting-ground control; exports it to Lineage II.

WEST NA servers closed June 2011.

CHAPTER NOTES

[L1-1] Porter's Five Forces — Brief History of NCsoft (founding, 1998 launch, KOSDAQ 2000).

[L1-2] Gamota Lab — From IMF Crisis to Gaming Empire (PC-bang licensing, no-cap tax, 50-60%).

[L1-3] Baidu Baike — Game Lineage (prince-only pledges, siege procedure, crown-before-sunset).
[L1-4] DualShockers — How Lineage Put South Korea On The MMO Map (\$1.49M/1998, 1M users, castles).
[L1-5] IGN 2001 — Lineage: The Blood Pledge (~4M subscriptions; Lord British promo siege).
[BZ-1]/[BZ-3] DK's Deporoju hunting-ground control as Lineage's first (Inven; NamuWiki).
[RD-1] repo dossier docs/research-notes/lineage1/findings.md (karma tint, siege crowd).



Helbreath: The Eternal Crusade

Siementech, 1999 — two churches, one battlefield

On full-war nights, every user
cancels their personal plans.

— Siementech company profile, 2001

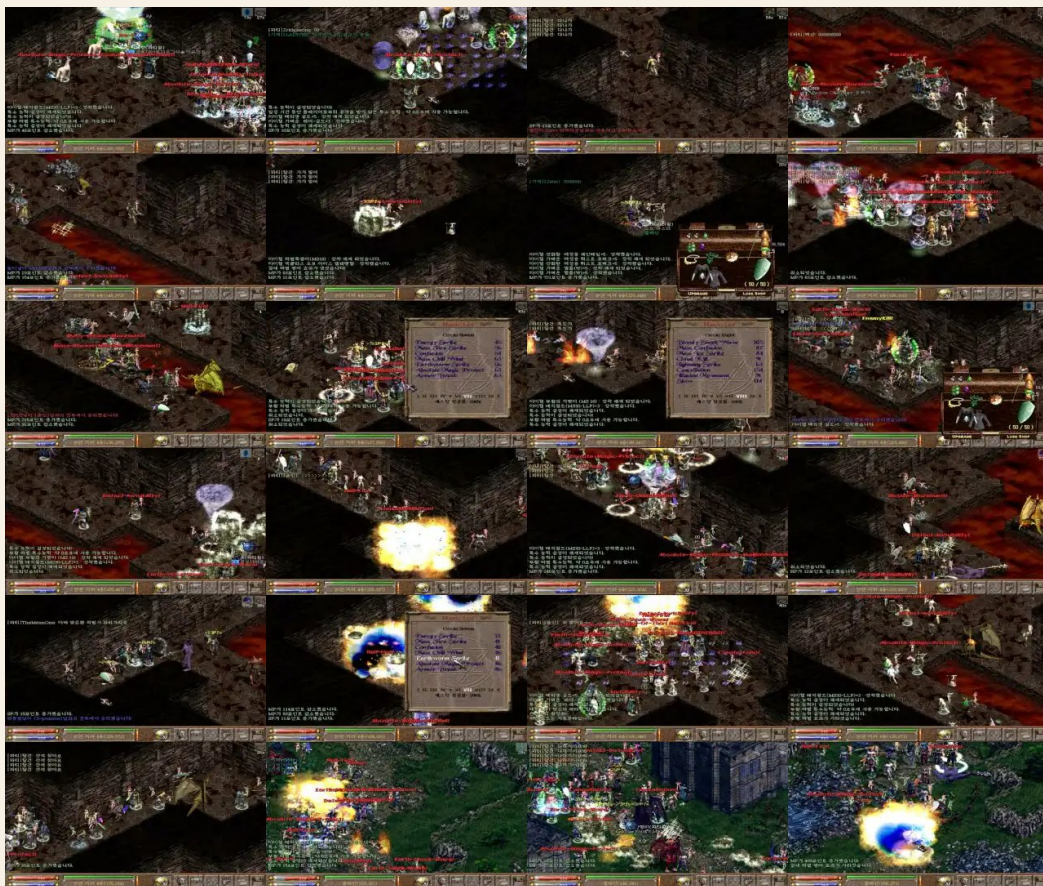
Helbreath began development in 1998 at Siementech, a venture of young developers, and opened in Korea in 1999 — August by the international records, November by the Korean press; treat the month as **contested**. Within two months it claimed a hundred thousand users, and export enquiries arrived from Spain and Japan. Its premise was the purest political machine of the era: two theocracies, Aresden (red, faithful to Aresien) and Elvine (blue, faithful to Eldiniel), in a war with no victory condition.

The machine had a constitution. A new player was a neutral Traveler, hard-capped at level 19 until choosing citizenship — every citizen was a convert, and conversion was permanent enmity. Citizens chose Civilian status (safe from enemies, prey to monsters) or Combatant (fair game for the other nation). Killing enemy combatants earned EK — Enemy Kill — points, and EK bought the Hero Armor of your church, red or blue: status worn as uniform, exactly the legibility the era prized.

In July 2001 Siementech shipped the Crusade upgrade and turned the war into a schedule. Twice a week the nations met in full war; on war nights, the company profile boasted, users cancelled their personal appointments. Players drew roles like a real campaign — soldier, builder, commander — and the objective was industrial: attackers raised mana collectors in the Middleland until the enemy town's defense shield collapsed, while defenders contested every collector site. Because the collectors mattered more than the duels, even low-level players could sway a crusade — the earliest documented case of a game designing mass participation into its politics.



ILLUSTRATION (AI) Aresden crimson against Elvine azure on the Middleland: the twice-weekly full war.



ARCHIVAL FRAME – repo dossier helbreath Archival frames from the Korean official server: crusade combat in the dungeons and fields, green party names, town shields under pressure.

Every year in November and December Siementech ran a national guild tournament, formalizing the guild layer beneath the national one. But the state's foundations were client-side: security checks lived on players' PCs, and the record shows the bill — dupes, item creation,

hacked GM accounts, 'tigerworm' spawns in Middleland, a p2p crack. When the level cap rose to 160 and then 180 and the service went pay-to-play, much of the West defected; in 2002 the server sources leaked and a private-server diaspora — Olympia among the famous — carried the war beyond Siementech's reach, pursued by cease-and-desist letters to ISPs. The Korean server outlived its maker.



ARCHIVAL FRAME — repo dossier helbreath Archival frames from a private-server crusade (Olympia lineage): the war continued outside the official state, on leaked law.

DOSSIER — HELBREATH

DEVELOPER Siementech (Korea). Dev from 1998; 1999 release (Aug intl / Nov KR: contested).

NATIONS Aresden (red, Aresien) vs Elvine (blue, Eldiniel); Traveler cap lvl 19.

STATUS Civilian vs Combatant; EK points -> Hero Armor.

WAR Crusade update 2001-07: twice-weekly full wars; mana collectors break town shields.

ROLES soldier / builder / commander on war nights; national guild war Nov-Dec.

COLLAPSE cap riots 160->180; P2P switch; 2002 source leak; private-server diaspora.

CHAPTER NOTES

[HB-4] koit.co.kr 2001 — Siementech profile (dev 1998, commercialization Nov 1999, Crusade July 2001, roles, guild war).

[HB-5] Hankyoreh 1999-12-26 — 100k users in two months; Spain/Japan enquiries.

[HB-1]/[HB-7] Wikipedia/en-academic/second.wiki — release dates, citizenship, EK, hero armor colors.

[HB-3] helbreath.net event log — living crusade/siege/relic/apocalypse schedule.

[HB-6] r/Games 2019 retrospective — mana-collector crusades, low-level participation, Olympia.

[HB-2] mmorpg.com 2004 — gods' war lore; hacking and client-side security sins.



Dark Eden: The Night Economy

SOFTON, 2000/2002 — the state that runs on a clock

The sun never rose over Helea again;
the vampires made it a constitution.

— after the Dark Eden creation myth

Dark Eden is the first horror MMORPG, and its horror was administrative. In the quarantined province of Helea, in the fictional Eslania, three master vampires — Vlad Tepes, Elizabeth Bathory, Gilles de Rais — failed to wake Lilith and instead blotted out the sun. Development began in the late 1990s at SOFTON (then Metrotech); the Korean alpha dates to June 2000, the open beta to July 2001, official service to 2002 — while a fandom genealogy claims 1997; treat the birth year as **contested** and the darkness as permanent.

The game's master stroke was the clock. Full day ran 9:00 to 16:59, when vampires were weakest and Slayers ruled; full night 21:00 to 4:59, when the same vampire who fled you at lunch could erase you; the hours between were transition, parity. Power itself was scheduled, so politics was too: raids were planned like tide tables, and the races' asymmetric economies — Slayers selling monster heads highest, Vampires drawing the best drops, Ousters leveling fastest — made each faction need the others' territories at the wrong hours.

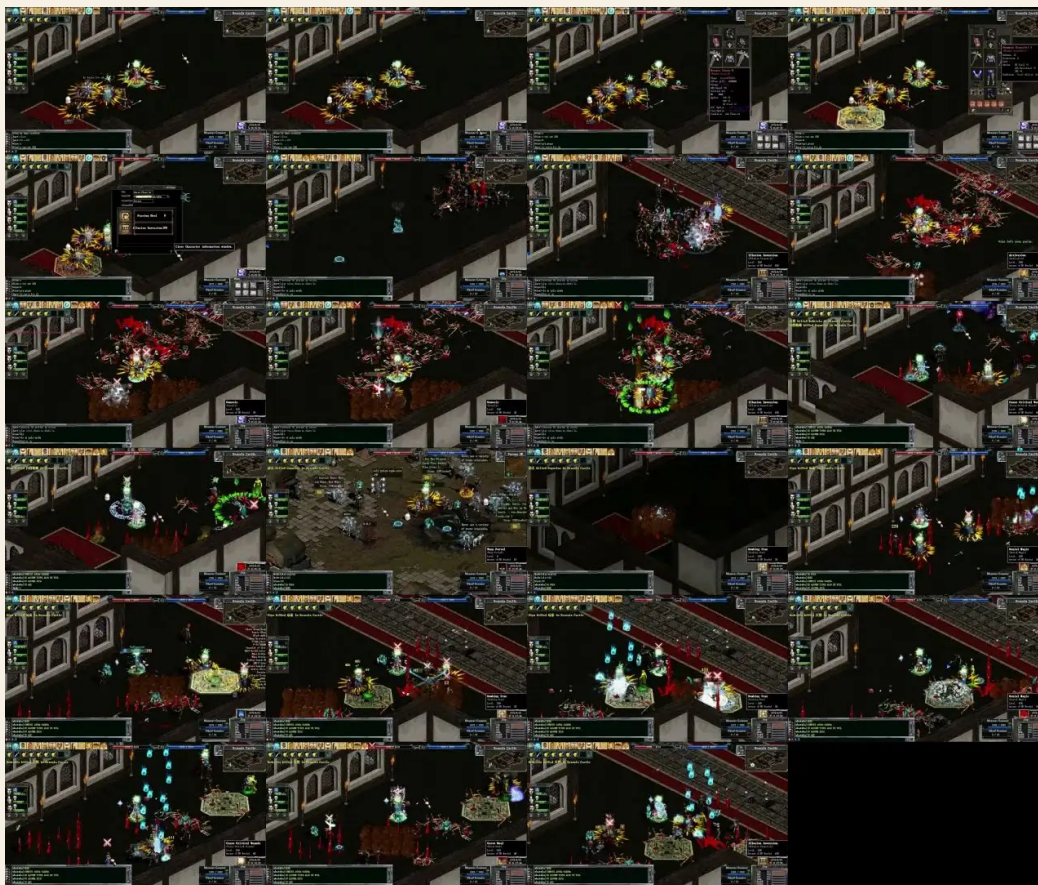


ILLUSTRATION (AI) Helea under the cloud: hunters with lanterns, pale shapes on the roofs, the chapel cross still lit. Between 21:00 and 04:59 this street belongs to the other side.

Race Wars, Castle Wars and Caligo Wars gave the hatred a calendar; the market town of Perona gave it a price floor — free players were locked out of the trading hub until they paid. A bitten human could turn vampire mid-career, and a vampire could buy his way back to humanity: allegiance in Dark Eden was literally convertible, which made every defection legible as a transaction. The lore promised thirteen Blood Bibles; players collected twelve and asked where

the thirteenth was. The operators answered: in development. It never shipped. A state that prints a prophecy and never honors it teaches its citizens what to believe about the state.

The foreign chapters read like a cautionary treaty. Netmarble ran a parallel Korean service from November 2002 on separate servers. In China, SOFTON signed for roughly forty percent royalties and collected, by its own account, nothing; the partner renamed the game and operated it as its own, and the server and client sources leaked into the wild — pirate servers haunted the Korean service for years. A second Chinese contract leaked again. Japan ran seven years before closing on 30 September 2013; North America flickered 2011 to 2013; a Steam relaunch arrived in 2016. The Korean original, four servers, one of them non-PK, outlasted them all.



ARCHIVAL FRAME — repo dossier dark-eden Archival frames, Korean Dark Eden PvP: the race war at street level, neon on black.

DOSSIER — DARK EDEN

DEVELOPER SOFTON (ex-Metrotech), Korea. Alpha 2000-06-15; beta 2001-07; service 2002; 1997 claim contested.

RACES Slayers (heads), Vampires (drops), Ousters (XP); biting converts; cures exist.

CLOCK full day 9:00-16:59; full night 21:00-4:59; transitions parity.

WARS Race Wars, Castle Wars, Caligo Wars; Perona market paywalled.

LORE DEBT 13th Blood Bible promised, never shipped.

EXPORTS Netmarble mirror 2002; China royalty disaster + double source leak; JP closed 2013-09-30; NA 2011-13; Steam 2016-11-28.

CHAPTER NOTES

[DE-1]/[DE-2]/[DE-3] fandom/Gamia/Wikipedia — races, clock windows, asymmetries, version history.

[DE-5] NamuWiki (EN) — 2001 beta / 2002 service; Netmarble Nov 2002; China royalty disaster and leaks; JP/NA closures.

[DE-4] Massively OP 2015 — 'one of the older continuously running graphical MMORPGs'.

[RD-4] repo dossier docs/research-notes/dark-eden/findings.md.



Myth of Soma: The Small Kingdom

Comnjoy, 2000-2005 — the war that had a TV show

The warrior of light, Soma!

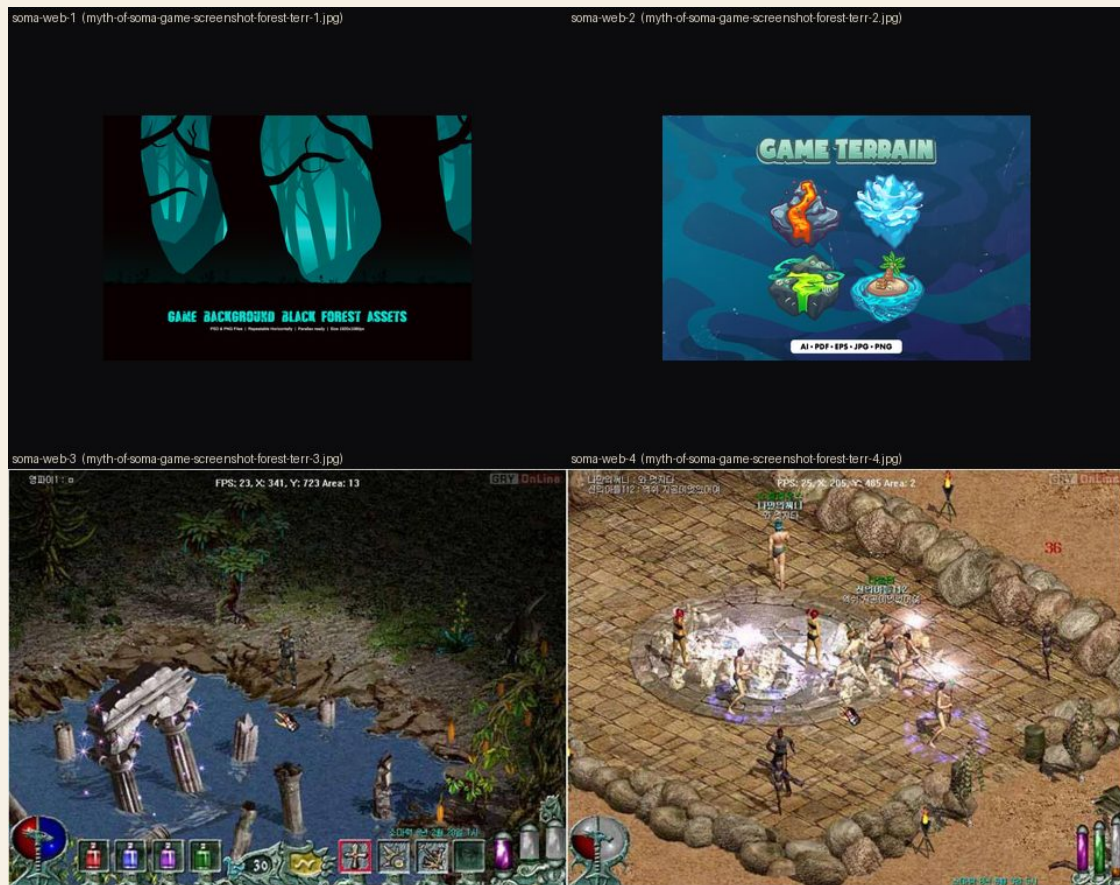
— original Korean promotional poster

Myth of Soma — Soma Sinhwa Jeongi — launched in Korea around 2000-2001 from Comnjoy, passed through Wizgate and MGame, and fought its eternal war between the Human world and the Devil world after the Great War started by Macheonru of the Monster world, ended once by the hero Pacheon King's cast-down sword. It was a smaller kingdom than Lineage, and its smallness is the point: it shows the template working at village scale.

Humans and Devils ground, crafted, and met in scheduled territorial wars — the War of the Worlds — plus guild wars over castles. The European edition, published by Game Network (with Digital Bros in Italy), had something no rival could claim: its own television program on the GameNetwork satellite channel, broadcasting the war into living rooms. In Korea the balance never held; the official service ended on 31 May 2005, drained by balance problems and declining numbers. The European server followed on 31 March 2009 after the late 2008 hackings finished the decline — and then the faithful did what Helbreath's faithful had done: a community team, SomaDev, resurrected the abandoned client and still runs it.



ILLUSTRATION (AI) The small kingdom at war: humans on the marble heights, devils up the scorched slope.



ARCHIVAL FRAME — repo dossier soma Archival frames, Myth of Soma web captures: painted-plate terrain cut into diamonds — the ground grammar this repo's art pipeline inherits.

Soma's afterlife matters to this folio's anatomy chapter: it is the cleanest case of a player-state surviving the death of its government. The war continued without the king — which is to say, the politics were always the players'.

DOSSIER — MYTH OF SOMA

DEVELOPER Comnjoy (KR), later Wizgate -> MGame. KR 2000/01 - 2005-05-31.

WAR Human vs Devil; territorial War of the Worlds; castle guild wars; crafting.

EUROPE Game Network / Digital Bros; its own TV show on the GameNetwork channel.

DEATHS KR 2005-05-31 (balance, decline); EU 2009-03-31 after 2008 hackings.

AFTERLIFE SomaDev community revival of the abandonware client.

CHAPTER NOTES

[SO-1] mmorpg.com — faction war, classes, release framing.

[SO-2] myth-of-soma.com guide — 2001 GameNetwork launch, TV show, 2008 hackings.

[SO-3] Myth of Soma fandom — Comnjoy/Wizgate/MGame; KR end 31 May 2005; publishers by region.

[RD-5] repo dossier docs/research-notes/soma/findings.md (terrain lock, night cap).



Lineage II: The Bartz Liberation War

NCsoft, 2003-2008 — the first citizen revolution online

Even a level-1 character, if dozens
gather, strikes them in mind as well as body.

— Bartz alliance appeal, 2004

When Lineage II opened its beta on 6 July 2003, the blood pledge DK — Dragon Knights, the name of the Deporoju dynasty though a distinct organization — moved to the first server, Bartz, and by 14 September 2003 had sealed a triple alliance with the Gods' Knights and Genesis pledges. Their leader Akirus held the server's first level 51 by August. What followed, from June 2004 to March 2008, involved cumulative two hundred thousand participants and is the largest documented player war in history: the Bartz Liberation War.

THE GRIEVANCES

DK ruled by the Deporoju playbook, upgraded: hunting grounds monopolized so that no one outside the alliance could realistically pass level 52; auto-macro (oto) farms printing adena around the clock; purge orders (cheoksallyeong) killing the disobedient on sight; castles taxed at will. In 2004 the alliance raised every territory's tax from ten to fifteen percent. For players under level 40 — who must buy weapons, armor, potions and spell books from NPC shops — that was not a policy change but a cost-of-living crisis. The tax made the revolution.

GIRAN, ZERO PERCENT

On 9 May 2004 the pledge Red Revolution (Bulgeun Hyeokmyeong), fifty strong, took Giran castle from DK in a guerrilla gamble and declared the tax at zero percent. DK's counter-siege retook the castle within two weeks — but the image of a zero-percent proclamation had already left the server. Small pledges that had stayed neutral for a year began to register for war, and players from other servers began rerolling naked beginners on Bartz. They wore only the starting underwear the game gives a fresh character, and they called themselves the Naebok-dan — the underwear corps.



ILLUSTRATION (AI) The Naebok-dan at a village gate: unarmored beginners from every server, holding the road against the alliance's armored march.

THE APOSTASY OF GENESIS

In June 2004 Genesis — one of the three thrones of the DK alliance — broke with DK over a petty insult, posted a public apology, and defected to the coalition. In July the coalition, grown to thirty-two pledges, took Oren. Then came the war's finest trick. Siege law required registration a day ahead; ten minutes before the deadline, the coalition flipped its registrations: every pledge but Genesis withdrew from the Aden attack and registered to defend Oren. DK, reading an Aden siege, marched its main body out of Aden toward Oren — and met at the gate the Naebok-dan, hundreds of them, blocking the road and piling their own corpses as a barricade to slow the march. DK burned through them with forced-attack, losing items to death penalties in its panic, and arrived too late: the feigned retreat had doubled back, wiped the archer corps left to hold Aden, and killed the DK lord shadow-Yeosol. Genesis's Kalitzeubeuk touched the seal. The day was declared Bartz Liberation Day; the forums filled for weeks; real newspapers ran the story.

THE SPOILS

Revolutions rot at the treasury. Revenge took Oren; Genesis took Aden; Red Revolution, which had lit the fire and lost Giran for it, received nothing. When Giran finally fell, the quarrel became a schism; an anti-Red-Revolution bloc declared war on the original revolutionaries, and Red Revolution — the pledge of the zero-percent proclamation — defected to DK. The server's mood curdled into the phrase historians of Bartz quote: the four-bloods are bad, but the anti-four-bloods are worse. The Naebok-dan's name was borrowed by robbers; the moral economy collapsed.

THE TERROR AND THE END

DK retook every castle by late 2004 and hid its elite in the Tower of Insolence. On 27 January 2005 it reissued an unlimited purge order; on some days the alliance killed seven hundred logged-in former coalition members. Akirus directed the counterattack personally, his nine-man guard scattering coalition front lines. In May 2006 he dissolved DK voluntarily, leaving the war's most quoted sentence: DK chose evil over good, and because evil existed, good could shine

brighter. A second war flared in 2007 when neutral pledges formed a Neutral League; it burned out by March 2008. Six years of Bartz history closed, and the war passed into culture — comics, literature, an art exhibition, and an essay by the novelist and professor Lee In-hwa, who called it the first citizen revolution online.

DK chose evil over good; because evil existed, good could shine brighter.

Akirus, dissolving the Dragon Knights, May 2006

YEAR	EVENT
2003-07-06	Lineage II OBT opens; DK establishes itself on Bartz (1st server).
2003-08	Akirus first on the server to level 51.
2003-09-14	Triple alliance: DK + Gods' Knights + Genesis.
2004 (early)	Tax raised 10% -> 15% across DK territories; purges expand.
2004-05-09	Red Revolution takes Giran with 50; declares 0% tax; loses it in 2 weeks.
2004-06	Genesis defects to the coalition with a public apology.
2004-07	Coalition grows to 32 pledges; takes Oren.
2004-07-17	Aden siege: registration feint, Naebok-dan corpse barricade, Aden falls. Bartz Liberation Day.
2004-11	DK stripped of Giran and Gludio; retreats to Tower of Insolence.
2005-01-27	Unlimited purge order; ~700 kills on some days.
2006-05	Akirus dissolves DK. First war ends.
2007-2008	Second war (Neutral League); conflict winds down by 2008-03.

DOSSIER – BARTZ LIBERATION WAR

THEATRE Lineage II, Bartz (1st) server; spillover from every KR server.

PARTIES DK alliance (DK, Gods' Knights, Genesis, later Revenge et al.) vs Bartz coalition + Naebok-dan.

SCALE cumulative ~200,000 participants; 2004-06 to 2008-03.

CAUSES hunting-ground monopoly; auto-macro economy; purges; 10->15% tax.

AFTERLIFE comics, literature, art exhibition; Lee In-hwa essay (Shin Dong-A, 2005-08).

CHAPTER NOTES

[BZ-1] Inven 2014 — full narrative: 0% Giran, Naebok-dan, Aden feint, 700/day purges, dissolution.

[BZ-2] ko.wikipedia — dates 2004-06 to 2008-03; prelude of 9 May 2004.

[BZ-3] NamuWiki — tax 10->15%; registration feint detail; second war 2007.

[BZ-4] Shin Dong-A 2005-08, Lee In-hwa — 'first citizen revolution'; 52+ level monopoly; 700 killed in one evening.

[BZ-5] gameinsight press kit — 200k participants, 4 years, cultural afterlife.

[L1-2]/[L1-3] DK's Lineage 1 Deporoju antecedent.



EverQuest Goes East

SOE x NCsoft x UbiSoft x Gamania, 2000-2006 — the empire that missed the market

We will provide the opportunity for players to transfer characters to US servers.

— the Chinese farewell, 2005

EverQuest was the West's cathedral: slow, vertical, devout. Between 2000 and 2006 it attempted to naturalize in Korea, China, Taiwan and Japan, and the attempt is the era's best-documented collision between two MMO cultures. Korea got it first, by import: on 30 August 2000 Hanbitsoft shipped the Ruins of Kunark expansion as a package — English client, Korean manual, eleven thousand won a month — selling subscriptions to American servers rather than running any.

On 23-24 January 2002 Sony Online Entertainment and NCsoft signed the real alliance: NCsoft would localize and host EverQuest for Korea, Taiwan and Hong Kong. Closed beta ran in June 2002, open beta in July, with Kunark folded in by October; commercial service began in April 2003 on Scars of Velious, and pieces of Luclin followed in August. NCsoft even bent the physics for the market: new characters regenerated abnormally fast to level 20, a concession to a player base raised on Lineage's tempo.

It was not enough. The Korean player of 2003 sat-to-regen in EverQuest and starved for Lineage; the WASD keyboard felt like arithmetic. In November 2003 NCsoft announced the end; the Korean servers ran free through 31 December 2003 and then died, weeks after Lineage II's October launch, with characters offered passage to North America — and the community's verdict that NCsoft had unplugged EverQuest to feed Lineage 2's server farm. A devoted remnant crossed the ocean and still plays there.

China followed the same arc a year slower. SOE and Ubi Soft announced the mainland deal on 19 September 2002; Shanghai Ubi Soft opened the Chinese EverQuest in 2003 and grew it past four hundred thousand veteran players; then the contract expired, management faltered, and on 31 January 2005 the lights went out, with the same consolation: transfer to the English servers, sixty days free. In Taiwan, Gamania ran the traditional Chinese service from October 2002.

The sequel repeated the lesson with interest. EverQuest II: East — a specially localized edition for China, Taiwan and Korea, shipped April 2005 with Gamania — died on 29-30 March 2006 of its localization's bad reputation, even in populous China. The accounts were deported en masse: Chinese characters to Mistmoore, Taiwanese to Najena, Koreans to Unrest, where the exiled Korean guilds consolidated into Chosen and WURI before the lag and the hack-waves thinned them. Korea's own EQ2 local service closed on 2 March 2006. Only Japan escaped the pattern: its non-East EQ2 localization survived as the one functioning Asian server — the exception that indicts the rest.



ILLUSTRATION (AI) Norrath at dawn, empty: the server-select screen as ghost town.

DOSSIER — EVERQUEST EAST

2000-08-30 Hanbitsoft imports EQ1 (Kunark) to KR: package + subscription, no servers.

2002-01-23 SOE x NCsoft alliance: KR/TW/HK localization and hosting.

2002-07 KR open beta; 2003-04 commercial (Velious); newbie regen boost to lvl 20.

2003-12-31 KR servers die, weeks after L2's Oct 2003 launch.

2003/2005 CN via Shanghai Ubi Soft (2002-09-19 deal; 400k vets) closed 2005-01-31.

2005/2006 EQ2: East (Gamania) dies 2006-03-29/30; KR accounts -> Unrest (Chosen, WURI).

EXCEPTION Japan's non-East EQ2 localization survives.

CHAPTER NOTES

[EQ-1] ko.wikipedia EverQuest — Hanbitsoft 2000-08-30; NCsoft CBT/OBT/commercial dates; shutdown 12-31; regen boost; EQall.

[EQ-3] SOE milestones — 2002-01-23 alliance; 2003-04-16 KR / 2003-04-28 CN commercial launches.

[EQ-2] Sony press release 2002-09-19 — Ubi Soft mainland China deal.

[EQ-4] Baidu Baike / zh.wikipedia — CN run from 2003-01, 400k players, closed 2005-01-31, transfers; TW Gamania 2002-10-03.

[EQ-5]/[EQ-6] Wikipedia EQ2 / NamuWiki — EQ2: East failure; Mistmoore/Najena/Unrest transfers; KR close 2006-03-02; Japan survives.



The Chinese Mirror

Legend of Mir 2/3 — Sabak, and the price of a sabre

The weapon was not real property
protected by law.

— as reported from the Shanghai police, 2005

WeMade's Legend of Mir 2 crossed to China as Shanda's Re Xue Chuan Qi and became the first MMO monoculture: entire cafes playing one server, guilds as companies, and the sandstone castle of Sabak (Shabake) as the nation's capital. Sabak sieges were Korean siegecraft translated intact — gate, courtyard, seal — but scaled to a market where a castle's tax roll could employ real people. Guild politics in Mir China was not metaphor; it was payroll.



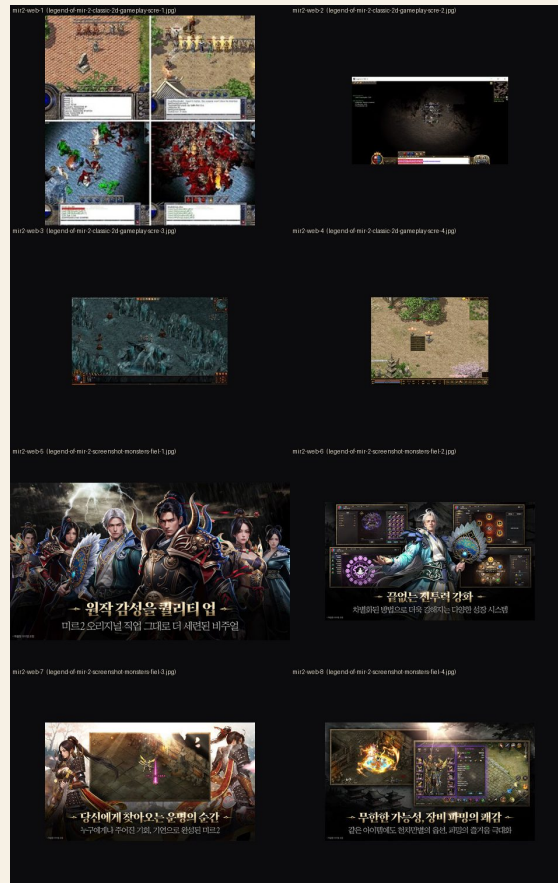
REFERENCE FRAME – Legend of Mir (WeMade), community capture Sabak culture in the flesh: fire pillars over the contest hall, the Korean siege grammar translated and payroll-sized.

In 2005 the mirror showed the era its true face. Qiu Chengwei, 41, and a friend had won a Dragon Sabre in Legend of Mir 3 and lent it to Zhu Caoyuan, 26, who sold it for 7,200 yuan — roughly US\$870, five times Shanghai's average monthly wage. Qiu reported the theft; the police answered that a virtual object was not property the law protected. So Qiu collected the debt himself, at Zhu's home, with a knife. The Shanghai No. 2 Intermediate People's Court sentenced him to death with a two-year reprieve — the standard Chinese suspended death sentence. Contemporary analysts estimated the grey market in virtual goods at one hundred million to one billion dollars a year.



REFERENCE PHOTO — r/SWORDS community photo, stand-in for the Dragon Sabre A willow-leaf dao of the family the Shanghai court was asked to price at 7,200 yuan — five times a monthly wage.

The case is the folio's hinge between politics and property. Every tax in Lineage, every monopoly in Bartz, every head-price in Dark Eden was a claim about who owns the virtual. Shanghai answered that the state does not — and then spent the next decade building the legal machinery that says it partly does. The players had known all along.



ARCHIVAL FRAME — repo dossier mir2 Archival frames, Legend of Mir 2 web captures: the grind texture and refine theatre this repo's dossiers audit.

CHAPTER NOTES

- [MR-1] Sydney Morning Herald 2005-03-30 — facts of the sabre sale, police refusal, stabbing.
 [MR-2] The Guardian gamesblog 2005-06-09 — suspended death sentence; RMT at \$100M-\$1B.
 [MR-3] china.org.cn — Shanghai No. 2 Intermediate Court proceedings.
 [RD-6] repo dossier docs/research-notes/mir2/findings.md.



Darkfall: The Western Heir

Aventurine (Greece) x MGame (Korea), 2009-2016 — full loot, merged flags

Without passion, there is no drama.

— Aventurine community, on Unholy Wars, 2012

A correction first, because the folio's rule is to flag rather than smooth: there was never a 1999-vintage 'Darkfall Korea'. Darkfall is Greek — Aventurine S.A. of Athens — a 2009 sandbox of unrestricted PvP, full looting, skill-based combat, city and house ownership, naval warfare and clan politics in which espionage, lying and cheating were declared legitimate statecraft. Its official servers closed on 15 November 2012. The Korean chapter comes later, and it is real.

In May 2012 Aventurine signed MGame to run Darkfall in Asia; the original plan was Korea, China and Japan, but China's licensing wall held, and the service launched as a Korea-Japan merger — one server, two flags, a novelty MGame advertised hard. The sequel edition, Darkfall: Unholy Wars, was renamed for the market through a public contest: Darkfall: Janhokhan Jeonjaeng, 'the cruel war'. Joint Korean-Japanese closed tests ran in August and September 2013; open service began 30 October 2013.

For three years the merged server held the old faith: sea sieges between Korean and Japanese clans, full-loot ambushes on the trade roads, clan charters written in two languages. MGame's service ended on 30 September 2016, refunds through October; in 2017 Big Picture Games raised the bloodline again as Darkfall: Rise of Agon. The Greek war machine had needed a Korean dock to reach Asia — and the Korean players, who had invented the genre's politics, recognized their own reflection in the full-loot mirror.



REFERENCE FRAME — Darkfall (Aventurine S.A.), community capture Darkfall as the West built it: full loot, a burning horizon, the inventory is the war. The merged Korea-Japan server flew two flags over this sea.

DOSSIER — DARKFALL

DEVELOPER Aventurine S.A., Athens. DF1 2009; official close 2012-11-15.

FAITH full loot, FFA PvP, skill-based combat, city/house ownership, naval war; espionage legit.

KOREA MGame (Kwon I-hyung): Asia deal 2012-05; KR title 'Cruel War'; KR-JP merged server.

DATES CBTs 2013-08/09; launch 2013-10-30; service end 2016-09-30.

AFTER Rise of Agon (Big Picture Games), 2017.

CHAPTER NOTES

[DF-1] Wikipedia Darkfall — Aventurine, 2009, full loot, close 2012-11-15.

[DF-2] MMO Culture 2012 — MGame Asia deal (Korea confirmed; China hoped).

[DF-3] NamuWiki Darkfall (MGame) — launch 2013-10-30; end 2016-09-30.

[DF-4] Gametoc Hankyung 2013-08-14 — KR/Japan plan, China dropped; 'a game that encourages PK'.

[DF-5] Inven 2013 — Korean title contest; joint KR-JP CBTs.



Anatomy of Player Politics

Comparison, and the inheritance of BloodHollow

Politics is endgame.

— BloodHollow GDD, pillar 4

Nine worlds, one machinery. Legitimacy always came from a scarce office (castle lord, crown-toucher, citizen hero); revenue always came from a tax on circulation (shop tax, head prices, market gates); monopoly always targeted the means of training (hunting grounds, boss spawns, Tower of Insolence); and every state died the same three deaths — defection of a great vassal (Genesis), corruption of the liberators (Red Revolution), or exile of the people (server transfers, private-server diasporas).

LEVER	FORMS OBSERVED
LEGITIMACY	prince's charisma (L1); crown-touch (L1/L2); citizenship+EK (HB); race+clock (DE); clan level (L2).
REVENUE	shop tax, uncapped (L1/L2); head sales (DE); market-gate paywall (DE); macro farms (Bartz DK).
MONOPOLY	hunting-ground control (Deporoju, Bartz); boss monopolies; Tower refuge.
INTEL	pledge spies; forum appeals (Bartz); registration feints; siege-calendar manipulation.
PROPAGANDA	0% tax proclamation; Liberation Day; dissolution speech; apology letters (Genesis).
DEFECTION	Genesis 2004; Red Revolution to DK; EQ players to NA servers; KR guilds to Unrest.
EXILE	private-server diasporas (HB, Soma); account transfers (EQ CN/KR, EQ2E); server-hopping Naebok-dan.
DEATH	vassal defection; liberator corruption; popular exile — never siege defeat alone.

BloodHollow inherits the machinery deliberately. Our locked design pillars — scheduled sieges at Weeping Castle, town taxes that matter, EK leaderboards, alignment worn in the name band, XP debt and item-drop stakes — are each an answer to a specific failure mode in this book: sieges on a cadence so war becomes institution (Helbreath); taxes with consequences but floors against tyranny (Bartz's fifteen percent was the revolution); legible allegiance so reputation is political capital (every ancestor); stakes on death so that barricades of the willing mean something (the Naebok-dan). What we refuse is the ancestors' client-side trust and their uncapped tax — the two sins that duped Helbreath and radicalized Bartz.

The ground is dark, the sprites are bright, and the name is the uniform.

cross-ancestor finding, repo dossier index

EPILOGUE — DAWN AFTER THE SIEGE

Every server in this book eventually printed the same screen: maintenance notice, transfer offer, farewell letter. The castles outlived their lords and the lords outlived their servers; the

pledges, gray at the temples, reassemble on remaster shards and community revivals and register for the same sieges under the same names. What persisted was never the software. It was the habit of governing each other — the oldest player skill there is, and the one BloodHollow intends to teach again.



REFERENCE ART — pixel battlefield study, free stock (stockcake.com) Sunrise over a burned keep: the field empties, the banners stay. Every server in this book ends on a morning like this one.

APPENDIX A — GRAND TIMELINE

YEAR	EVENT
1997	IMF crisis; NCsoft founded 11 Mar; Aventurine-era Greece far away.
1998	Lineage launches in Korea (Sep).
1999	Helbreath opens in Korea; EQ ships in NA; 100k HB users in two months.
2000	Dark Eden alpha (Jun); Hanbitsoft imports EQ to KR (Aug); Soma beta/launch; Soma KR.
2001	HB Crusade update (Jul); DE open beta (Jul); Mir 2 to China (Shanda); Soma EU on GameNetwork TV.
2002	S0E x NCsoft EQ alliance (Jan); EQ2-era DE official service; Netmarble DE mirror (Nov); HB source leak.
2003	EQ KR commercial (Apr) and death (31 Dec); L2 OBT (Jul); DK triple alliance (Sep); EQ CN opens.
2004	Bartz: 10->15% tax; Giran 0% (9 May); Aden falls (17 Jul); Liberation Day.
2005	EQ CN closes (31 Jan); Soma KR ends (31 May); Mir 3 Dragon Sabre murder, Shanghai; EQ2: East ships.
2006	EQ2: East dies (Mar); KR accounts -> Unrest; Akirus dissolves DK (May).
2007-08	Second Bartz war; winds down 2008-03.
2009	Soma EU closes (Mar); Darkfall launches (Greece).
2011-13	L1 West closes (Jun 2011); DE NA closes; DE JP closes 2013-09-30; DF1 closes 2012-11-15; DF KR-JP launches 2013-10-30.
2016	DF MGame service ends (30 Sep); DE Steam relaunch (28 Nov).

APPENDIX B — GLOSSARY

TERM	MEANING
hyeolmaeng (blood pledge)	Lineage's clan: a state in miniature, founded only by royalty.
gongseongjeon (siege war)	the scheduled battle for a castle and its tax.
naebok-dan	'underwear corps': naked beginner volunteers of the Bartz war.
cheoksallyeong	purge order: kill-on-sight decree against named players.
snaengteotongje	hunting-ground control: monopoly of XP/loot fields; the original sin.
EK (Enemy Kill)	Helbreath's kill ledger, redeemable for Hero Armor.
adena	Lineage's currency; its price was Bartz's inflation index.
jeonmyeonjeon / crusade	Helbreath's twice-weekly national war.
PC bang	the internet cafe: the room where the pledge was a neighbourhood.
jeong	the Korean bond of obligation; what made a blood pledge a family.

APPENDIX C — SOURCE REGISTRY

[L1-1] Porter's Five Forces — Brief History of NCsoft. [L1-2] Gamota Lab — From IMF Crisis to Gaming Empire.
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 [L1-5] IGN (2001) — Lineage: The Blood Pledge. [L1-6] mmorpg.com — Lineage.

[HB-1] Wikipedia/en-academic — Helbreath. [HB-2] mmorpg.com (2004) — Helbreath Review.
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[SO-1] mmorpg.com — Soma. [SO-2] myth-of-soma.com guide. [SO-3] Myth of Soma fandom.
[BZ-1] Inven (2014). [BZ-2] ko.wikipedia — Bartz Liberation War. [BZ-3] NamuWiki — Bartz. [BZ-4] Shin Dong-A (2005-08), Lee In-hwa. [BZ-5] gameinsight.co.kr.
[EQ-1] ko.wikipedia — EverQuest. [EQ-2] Sony press release (2002-09-19). [EQ-3] SOE milestones (P1999/B3D mirrors). [EQ-4] Baidu Baike / zh.wikipedia — EQ CN. [EQ-5] Wikipedia — EverQuest II. [EQ-6] NamuWiki — EQ2.
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[DF-1] Wikipedia — Darkfall. [DF-2] MMO Culture (2012). [DF-3] NamuWiki — Darkfall (MGame). [DF-4] Gametoc Hankyung (2013-08-14). [DF-5] Inven (2013).
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Compiled 2026-09-15 for the BloodHollow team. The prompt that produced this folio lives at docs/prompts/ancestral-chronicles-pdf-brief.md; the builder at tools/build_chronicles_pdf.py.